Announcements and reminders

<Midterm>

- **Friday, 6 March (Week 7), 2pm-3:30pm, MPSH 1A & 1B, NOT LT11**

  MPSH 1A : tutorial groups TW 10-18

  MPSH 1B : tutorial groups TW 1-9
- You must be physically present at the venue
- 1 hour and 30 minutes, 15-20 questions.
- Relevant materials: Weeks 2-5 lectures and readings.
- Some questions may require knowledge from the readings that isn't covered in class.
- The exam will be open book, meaning you may bring one sheet of paper (handwritten or printed, A4 or smaller, double-sided). You won't have access to the internet or files saved on your laptop.
- A past exam is posted on Canvas in the Files section.
- Bring your own laptop with Examplify installed (email me if you don't have a laptop)
- Fully charge your laptop before the exam and bring your own charger if you want to charge your laptop
- You'll need to download the exam before the exam starts—I'll make an announcement a few days before the exam about when it will be available for download (likely Thursday evening)
- You may use a pen or pencil during the exam, but please bring your own. No additional paper is allowed.
- You'll be able to use the built-in calculator in Examplify (though you won't need a calculator).

<Teaching Assistants of This Course>

Fan Sirui <siruifan@u.nus.edu> - W5, W6, W9, W14

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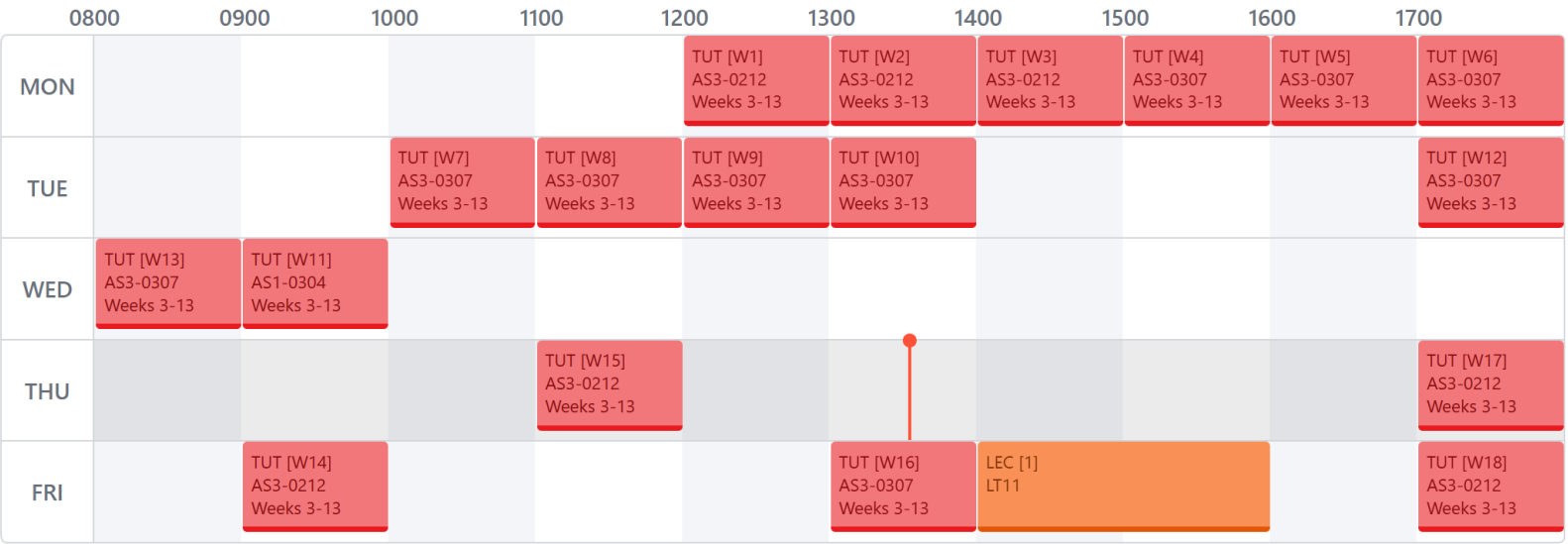
Youhei Shibukawa <youhei@u.nus.edu> - W7, W8, W10, W13, W11, W18



Announcements and reminders

- Please make sure that you're aware when your tutorial will be cancelled (contact your TA if you're unsure)
- Practice questions will be posted on Canvas early next week (I'll make an announcement after posting them)
- Special office hours for midterm preparation: 27 Feb (Friday) 3pm – 5pm on Zoom (the link will be available on Canvas in the Zoom section).

Religion

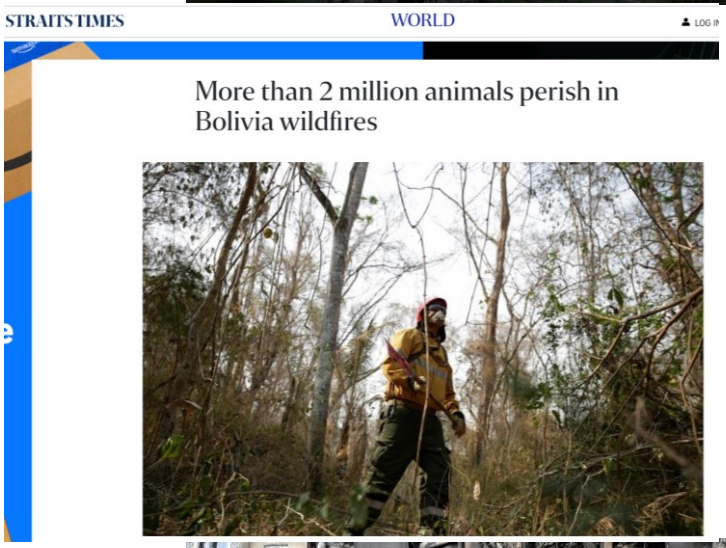
The Problem of Evil

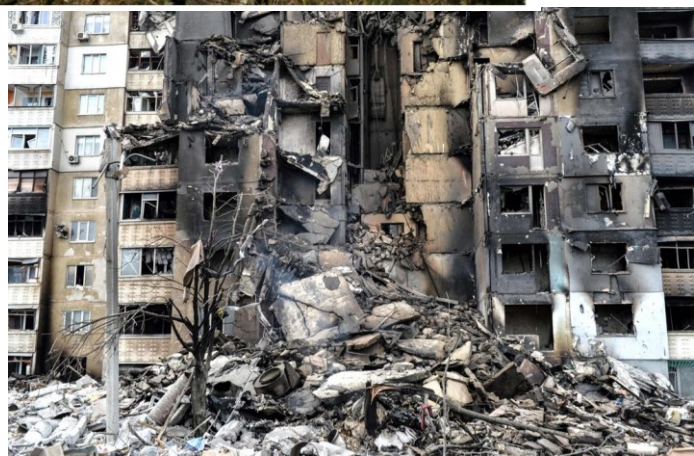
The Problem of **Evil**

Suffering, misfortune

(not immorality)

THE WAR IN YEMEN
19 MILLION MALNOURISHED
STARVATION & DISEASE KILL THOUSANDS
ALJAZEERA


STRAITS TIMES
WORLD
LOG IN
More than 2 million animals perish in Bolivia wildfires



Titian, The Rape of Europa

Some people argue against the existence of **a certain kind of god** based on the existence of such evils.

A god that has the following three features:

1. Omnipotent (all-powerful, with possible exceptions such as creating a round square)
2. Omniscient (all-knowing)
3. Omnibenevolent (all-loving, morally perfect)

Let's call this kind of god an all-perfect god.

(From now on, we'll focus only on an all-perfect god).

Here’s the basic idea behind the problem of evil.

Weirob

“You believe in a God that is perfect in every way. All-knowing, all-powerful, and benevolent…But how can this be? If your God exists, he knows I have the flu because he knows everything. He can certainly make it the case that I cease to have the flu, or could have prevented me from having the flu in the first place, for he is all-powerful. But I do have the flu! What am I to conclude? He must not care. But shouldn't a really benevolent God care about even a wretch like me? Why would he want me to suffer? But if he doesn't want me to suffer, why am I suffering?...There is no being that meets your definition of God . Perhaps there is no God. Or perhaps there is, but he is ignorant, or weak, or mean.” (p.4)

There are different ways to turn this basic idea into an argument.

An argument against the existence of god from evil – first attempt

P1. If an all-perfect god exists, there are no evils.

P2. There are evils.

C. An all-perfect god does not exist.

Let’s think about whether this argument is sound.

A sound argument is a good argument because..

if an argument is sound, its conclusion must be true.

- A **sound** argument is a **valid** argument whose **premises are all true.**

  Soundness = (1) validity + (2) all premises being true.

  Both conditions need to be met for an argument to be sound.

- A **valid** argument:

  Its premises and conclusion are connected in such a way that…

  if the premises are all true, the conclusion must be true as well.

  In other words, the conclusion follows from the premises.

  The premises, if all true, 100% guarantee the truth of the conclusion.

  (It doesn't matter whether the premises are actually true.)

  How to check whether an argument is valid:

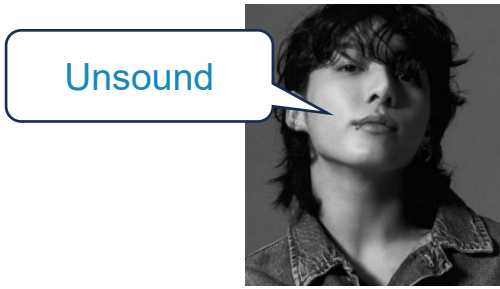
  Assume that all the premises are true and think about whether it is possible for the conclusion to be false.

  If yes, invalid. If no, valid.

  E.g.) P1. All philosophers are men.

  P2. Jungkook is a philosopher. Sound or unsound?

  C. Jungkook is a man.



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P2. There are evils.

C. An all-perfect god does not exist.

Let's think about whether this argument is sound.

First, is this argument valid?

(hint: it is equivalent to one of the four common argument forms you've learned)

No need to memorise the grey parts

(1) Always valid Modus Ponens (affirming the antecedent)

If A, then B
A.
Therefore, B.

(2) Always valid Modus Tollens (denying the consequent)

If A, then B
Not B.
Therefore, Not A.

(3) Always invalid

If A, then B
Not A.
Therefore, Not B.

(4) Always invalid

If A, then B
B.
Therefore, A.

An argument against the existence of god from evil – first attempt

P1. If an all-perfect god exists, there are no evils.

A B

P2. There are evils = It's not the case that there are no evils = not B

C. An all-perfect god does not exist. not A

Let's think about whether this argument is sound.

First, is this argument valid?

(hint: it is equivalent to one of the four common argument forms you've learned)

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Second, are the premises all true?

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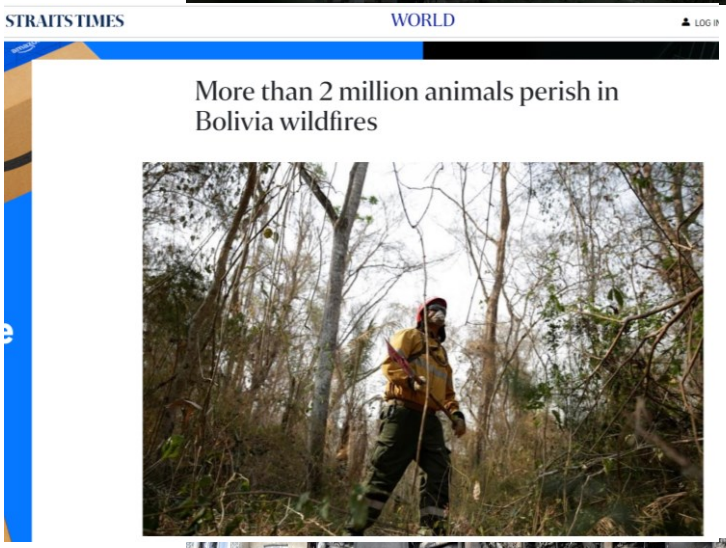
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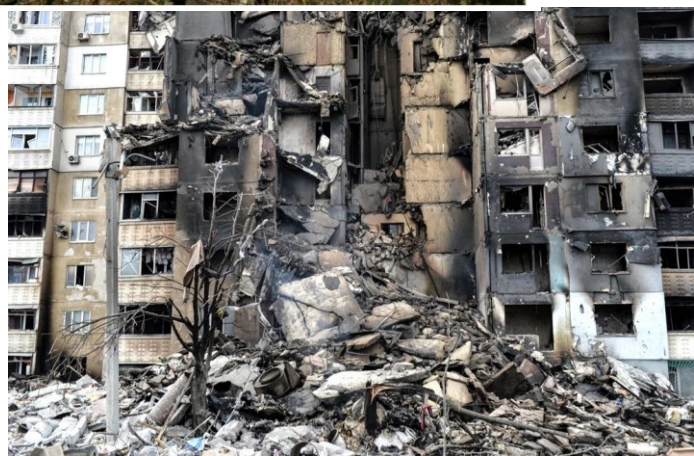

An argument against the existence of god from evil – first attempt

P1. If an all-perfect god exists, there are no evils.

P2. There are evils.

C. An all-perfect god does not exist.

Let's think about whether this argument is sound.

First, is this argument valid?

(hint: it is equivalent to one of the four common argument forms you've learned)

Second, are the premises all true?

P1 is clearly implausible because

God may have a good reason to allow some evils

"Think of the times we go fishing. Surely it is some form of mild suffering to get out of bed before dawn on a chilly Nebraska spring morning when one might sleep in. But the days as a whole, the days that start out with those unpleasant experiences, are some of the most enjoyable days one can imagine.

…

Just as we have a plan for spending a fine day fishing that has, as a necessary part, a little suffering early in the morning, so God may have a plan for the world that requires suffering. It still may be a fine world, a much better world than it would have been without the suffering" (p.4, p.9)

Miller

Let’s revise the argument so that
it doesn’t have a clearly implausible premise.

An argument against the existence of god from evil – second attempt

P1. If an all-perfect god exists, there are no unjustified evils.

Evils that an all-perfect god has no good reason to allow

P2. There are unjustified evils.

C. An all-perfect god does not exist.

Allowing the evil in question is **necessary** for achieving a **more important** moral goal (e.g., generating a good that outweighs the evil, preventing a more serious evil) ("necessary" here means that even an all-perfect god cannot achieve that goal without allowing the evil).

Now, let's evaluate this argument.

~~First, is this argument valid?~~

Second, are the premises all true? If yes, then theists should accept the conclusion!

Theists typically attack P2, by providing explanations as to how evils in the world are justified (that is, explanations as to what God's reasons for allowing the evils are or could be).
Note that theists would want to show that *all* evils in the world are justified.

Possible answer 1. We would not appreciate the good things in life unless we were exposed to bad things too.

Sure, but do we need so much evil to appreciate the good things in life?

Couldn't an all-perfect god make us such that we can appreciate good things without being exposed to bad things?

And what about bad things that happen without anyone knowing?

Possible answer 2. Evil is necessary for spiritual (moral/personal) development.

Again, do we really need so much horrendous evil for spiritual development?

And what about the suffering of animals or children who die young and suffering that no one notices?

Also, if the point of suffering is that it promotes spiritual development, why is it that those who really need spiritual development often do not suffer?

Possible answer 2. Evil is necessary for spiritual (moral/personal) development.

Again, do we really need so much horrendous evil for spiritual development?

And what about the suffering of animals or children who die young and suffering that no one notices?

Also, if the point of suffering is that it promotes spiritual development, why is it that those who really need spiritual development often do not suffer?

Those who suffer a lot often end up bitter, twisted, and morally crippled.

Couldn't an all-perfect god make us such that we are already spiritually mature without suffering?

Possible answer 3. Evil in our world is a necessary consequence of humans having free will

Do we really have free will, though this is the topic for next lecture?

Why doesn't an all-perfect god at least intervene sometimes, to prevent the most horrendous outcomes of free will (e.g., by ending World War 2 a bit early)?

Holocaust victims

11 languages

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From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

This article's **factual accuracy is disputed**. Relevant discussion may be found on the talk page. Please help to ensure that disputed statements are reliably sourced. *(October 2023)*
(Learn how and when to remove this message)

Holocaust victims were people targeted by the government of Nazi Germany based on their ethnicity, religion, political beliefs, disability or sexual orientation. The institutionalized practice by the Nazis of singling out and persecuting people resulted in the Holocaust, which began with legalized social discrimination against specific groups, involuntary hospitalization, euthanasia, and forced sterilization of persons considered physically or mentally unfit for society. The vast majority of the Nazi regime's victims were Jews, Sinti-Roma peoples, and Slavs but victims also encompassed people identified as social outsiders in the Nazi worldview, such as homosexuals, and political enemies. Nazi persecution escalated during World War II and included: non-judicial incarceration, confiscation of property, forced labor, sexual slavery, death through overwork, human experimentation, undernourishment, and execution through a variety of methods. For specified groups like the Jews, genocide was the Nazis' primary goal.

According to the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum (USHMM), the Holocaust was "the systematic, bureaucratic, state-sponsored persecution and murder of six million Jewish men, women and children by the Nazi regime and its collaborators".[1]

Estimates of victims

Victims	Murdered	Refs.
Jews	6 million	[1]
Soviet civilians	4.5 million	[2]
Soviet POWs	3.3 million	[3][1]
Poles	1.8 million	[4][5][1]
Serbs	More than 310,000	[6][7]
Disabled people	270,000	[8]
Romani	250,000–500,000	[1][9]
Freemasons	80,000	[10][11]
Slovenes	20,000–25,000	[12]
Homosexuals	5,000–15,000	[13]
Spanish Republicans	3,500	[14]
Jehovah's Witnesses	1,700	[1][15]
Total	17 million	

Possible answer 3. Evil in our world is a necessary consequence of humans having free will

Do we really have free will, though this is the topic for next lecture?

Why doesn't an all-perfect god at least intervene sometimes, to prevent the most horrendous outcomes of free will (e.g., by ending World War 2 a bit early)?

Does the importance of free will really outweigh the evils in the world?

Is our having free will compatible with the existence of an *omniscient* god?

God (and angels) presumably have free will and never commit any wrongdoing. Why, then, couldn't God make humans like that too?

Also, what about **natural evils**, which are not consequences of human free will (e.g., earthquakes, floods, tsunamis, volcanoes, cancer, etc.)?

An example of natural evil (that is particularly challenging for theists)

Suppose lightning strikes a tree in a remote forest, starting a wildfire. A fawn is unable to escape, is badly burned, and experiences prolonged suffering for several days before it dies. (We may also assume that this happens before any human beings existed.)

- None of the three possible answers discussed so far can easily justify this instance of evil.
- Then what could theists say?

Possible answer 4. Natural evils are caused by supernatural beings with free will (e.g., devils, fallen angels, etc.)

Do you expect me to find it plausible that such supernatural beings exist?

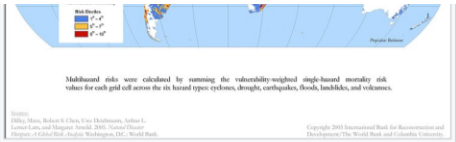
Why doesn't God stop them or at least intervene sometimes?

Possible answer 5. Natural evils are necessary consequences of there being laws of nature, which is good (perhaps because they enable effective human actions.)

Couldn't an all-perfect God create laws of nature that result in fewer, or at least less severe, natural evils than those we currently observe (for example, eliminating diseases such as cancer)? Or intervene to prevent at least the most terrible natural evils in ways that humans would not detect?

Ten deadliest natural disasters by highest estimated death toll excluding epidemics and famines [edit]

This list takes into account only the highest estimated death toll for each disaster and lists them accordingly. It does not include epidemics and famines. The list also does not include the 1938 Yellow River flood, which was caused by the deliberate destruction of dikes.

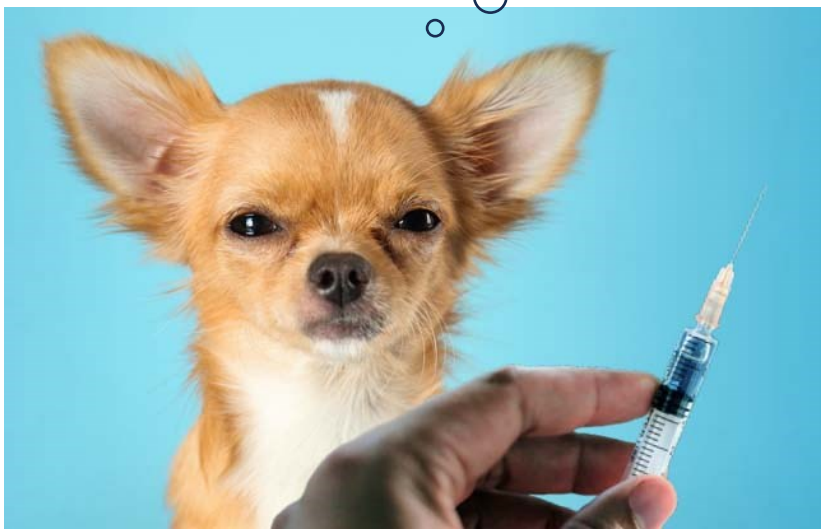


Global multihazard mortality risks and distribution (2005) for cyclones, drought, earthquakes, floods, landslides, and volcanoes (excluding heat waves, snowstorms, and other deadly hazards).

	Death toll (Highest estimate)	Event	Location	Date
1	4,000,000[1][a]	1931 China floods	China	July 1931
2	2,000,000[2][3][4]	1887 Yellow River flood		September 1887
3	655,000[5]	1976 Tangshan earthquake		July 28, 1976
4	500,000[6][1]	1970 Bhola cyclone	East Pakistan (now Bangladesh)	November 13, 1970
5	316,000[7]	2010 Haiti earthquake	Haiti	January 12, 2010
6	300,000[8]	526 Antioch earthquake	Byzantine Empire (now Hatay/Turkey)	May 526
7	≈300,000[9]	1839 Coringa cyclone	Andhra Pradesh, India	November 25, 1839
8	≈300,000[10]	1737 Calcutta cyclone	Bengal, India	October 1737
9	≈300,000[11]	1139 Ganja earthquake	Seljuk Empire (present-day Azerbaijan)	September 30, 1139
10	273,407[12]	1920 Haiyuan earthquake	China	December 16, 1920

Possible answer 6. God has good reasons to allow evils, but humans cannot understand those reasons due to their limitations.

This is an unjustified evil!



Possible answer 6. God has good reasons to allow evils, but humans cannot understand those reasons due to their limitations.

If God is all-loving, why doesn't he help us bear our suffering by enabling us to understand his reasons for permitting evil — or at least by making his presence more evident?

If this answer is correct, that means we don't know what is truly good. Then, it seems we lose our moral compass (e.g., we're unsure whether to prevent a suffering or not).

This also means that we can't predict how a god might behave. For example, we have no good reason to think that our afterlife will be good (in our sense of good).

As usual, I'll leave it up to you to think about
whether this argument from evil against the existence of an all-perfect god
is successful.

What to do this week

- The midterm exam will take place in Week 7. More information is available on the first slide.